

reforms are needed in industrial training institutes and vocational education, particularly through the widespread adoption of apprenticeship programmes. An innovative measure that must be facilitated is the lateral entry of industry and specialised domain experts into All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE)-approved institutions as professors or associates of practice. Regular updates and revisions of academic curricula are also essential to maintain their relevance and practicality.

In addition to these policy-driven measures, there is also significant potential for entrepreneurship in bridging the skills gap. For instance, Scaler Academy, a skill development firm, has successfully launched a comprehensive nine-month coding boot camp with its structured curriculum covering various essential technological skills. This programme has effectively doubled the average remuneration of its participants, underscoring the benefits of aligning education with industry needs. In a similar vein, Freshworks' Software Academy has partnered with Pupilfirst, a learning management system, to provide a robust training model for individuals from low-income backgrounds, who lack access to traditional college education. This initiative has been effectively piloted at Sastra University and subsequently extended to 27 government universities in collaboration with the AICTE, exemplifying a successful industry-academia partnership. The programme offers a specialised curriculum in full-stack development, with a focus on Software as a Service (SaaS) products, tailored to empower and elevate the participants' technological capabilities.

Finally, there is an urgent need to nurture an array of essential professional and life skills beyond technical proficiency to build adaptability in the workforce. At the forefront is the sharpening of cognitive prowess, especially in complex problem-solving, which will emerge as the linchpin for career triumph. Next, the dynamically evolving economic paradigm demands an interdisciplinary mindset, where merging analytical depth with creative flair isn't just advantageous—it's inescapable if one wishes to thrive. Finally, as an economy, we need to foster a culture steeped in curiosity and creativity. Lifelong learning should become an essential strategy for the workforce to remain a formidable and relevant contender in this new era.

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The ascent of AI marks a pivotal transition, heralding a future with limitless possibilities. This shift demands an agile and forward-thinking approach to skill development, as well as a strategic reassessment of our educational and vocational training systems. It is essentially important to proactively equip the workforce with the tools and knowledge needed for success. The Indian workforce should not only be prepared but also primed to thrive in the AI-infused horizon ahead. ■

Views are personal